A PRACTICAL FIELD GUIDE

# Intentional Images

## Human-led AI art direction

**Define what matters.**
**Inspect what appears.**
**Revise with a reason.**

Five frameworks help you describe an intention.
43 checks help you examine a result.
Your judgment determines the next step.

**CARL BOND**

With design checks adapted from u/Kaihzu's principles.
Written and designed with ChatGPT.

# Make the next decision clearer

For artists, designers, teachers, and anyone making an image with a purpose. Begin with one intention and one visible problem.

## 1 / Frame

Name the subject, audience, medium, format, and required facts. Pick one framework to organize your thinking.

## 2 / Inspect

Look at thumbnail size for composition and hierarchy. At full size, inspect material, light, edges, anatomy, object relationships, and every rendered word.

## 3 / Revise

Choose one priority. Name what must stay and the tradeoff you will accept. Review the instruction before generating or editing.

## 4 / Decide

Compare the whole result with the previous image. Keep, revise, reject, or stop. Record the reason, including anything that drifted.

> **Recomposition request**
> Describe what is visible and mark uncertainty. Given [intention], suggest up to three changes and their tradeoffs. Preserve [anchors]. Revise my original prompt if supplied; otherwise write a new prompt. Let me review the proposal before generating.

## Find what you need

03 Choose and understand the fields

05 Five filled framework examples

07 A complete poster revision

11 Typography and delivery

12 43 design checks

15 Completed record and reusable worksheet

17 Sources, credits, and reuse

# Start where the difficulty is

Use one framework first. Add another only when a specific remaining problem calls for it. The questions below are practical entry points, not rigid boundaries. [1]

## F.O.C.U.S. / Building Core Structure

Start here when the subject or composition is unclear.

**Fields:** Focal Subject / Overall Setting / Composition Layout / Unique Detail / Sensory Tone

## V.I.S.I.O.N. / Bringing Interaction and Narrative

Start here when the relationship or story is hard to see.

**Fields:** Visual / Illumination / Subject / Interaction / Opacity / Narrative

## D.A.L.L.E. / Adding Finer Details

Start here when action or material distinctions are vague.

**Fields:** Details / Actor / Locomotion / Light / Environment

## P.A.N.E.L.S. / Refining Depth and Atmosphere

Start here when viewpoint, space, or atmosphere feels wrong.

**Fields:** Position / Ambience / Need / Environment / Lighting / Structure

## S.A.M.O.S.E.T. / Quick Conceptual Ignition

Start here when you have an idea but no concrete scene.

**Fields:** Subject / Action / Matter / Overall / Setting / Era/time / Theme

These are Carl Bond's image-planning mnemonics. D.A.L.L.E. here names a framework, not an official OpenAI method. You can write in plain language without using any acronym.

Framework source: [1]. Field explanations and entry questions are teaching aids.

# Turn a label into a choice

Use short phrases that could lead to visible decisions. The same word can serve different purposes in different briefs.

## Sensory Tone

The felt quality: tense, hushed, buoyant, exhausted. Support it with posture, color, spacing, or light.

## Visual

The overall visual treatment: painted shapes, line drawing, photography, collage, or another deliberate language.

## Opacity

How transparency, translucency, haze, or visibility affects the scene. For example: clear foreground air and a softened distant shore.

## Need

The emotional or sensory state the image reaches toward. For example: reassurance through a watchkeeper's steady presence.

## Matter

An additional element that contributes to the concept. A departing boat gives the watchkeeper something meaningful to watch.

## Overall

The broad look or mood that holds the concept together: restrained and tense, or exuberant and playful.

## Era/time

A historical period, time of day, or both. Specify only what the scene needs.

## Locomotion

The actor's movement or action, including stillness: standing, leaning, signaling, or walking.

An anchor is a quality you decide to preserve. A success condition is something you can inspect in the result. A prompt describes an intention; the image supplies the evidence.

# One subject, several decisions

Use this imagined harbor scene to practice turning an intention into visible choices. These planning entries can be used with any suitable image tool; they are not a generation transcript.

## F.O.C.U.S. / Establish the scene

**Focal Subject** - An adult harbor watchkeeper.

**Overall Setting** - A stone quay with open water beyond.

**Composition Layout** - Figure on the left; water and a small vessel on the right.

**Unique Detail** - A red signal lantern held in one hand.

**Sensory Tone** - Vigilance, fatigue, and resolve.

> **Inspect:** at small size, do the figure and lantern lead? If the background competes, revisit Composition Layout and the relative emphasis of the Unique Detail.

## V.I.S.I.O.N. / Make the relationship visible

**Visual** - A painted treatment with broad shapes and selected clear edges.

**Illumination** - Red lantern light within cool dusk.

**Subject** - The watchkeeper and a departing vessel.

**Interaction** - Watching the vessel while holding the signal lantern.

**Opacity** - Clear nearby air; distant haze only where it helps depth.

**Narrative** - Responsibility continues after someone leaves.

> **Inspect:** can the gaze or gesture communicate the relationship without a caption? A story in the prompt still needs visible support in the image.

## A first-pass prompt to adapt

Painted vertical illustration, 4:5. An adult harbor watchkeeper stands on the left of a stone quay at dusk, holding a red signal lantern and watching a small departing vessel across open water on the right. Let the face and lantern lead. Use broad painted shapes, deep blue water, a matte wool coat, translucent lantern glass, and selective reflections on wet stone. Keep the surrounding water quiet. Her posture and expression convey vigilance, fatigue, and resolve. No lettering.

Planning prompt: inspect the actual result before deciding what to revise.

# Specify only what earns its place

The same watchkeeper, approached through materials, atmosphere, and concept. These examples show distinct uses; they are not instructions to stack every field into one prompt.

## D.A.L.L.E. / Material and action

**Details:** Matte wool, translucent glass, selective reflections on wet stone.
**Actor:** The watchkeeper.
**Locomotion:** Standing and signaling.
**Light:** A concentrated red glow against soft blue ambient light.
**Environment:** The quay edge and harbor water.

Inspect the three materials separately. The brightest or sharpest treatment need not cover every surface.

## P.A.N.E.L.S. / Viewpoint and atmosphere

**Position:** Eye-level view from the quay.
**Ambience:** Cold, quiet, watchful.
**Need:** Reassurance through continued vigilance.
**Environment:** Stone, water, distant sky.
**Lighting:** Low light; broad shadows remain dark.
**Structure:** A vertical figure against a horizontal horizon.

Need names the emotional or sensory state the image reaches toward. Atmosphere can come from space and light without adding fog.

## S.A.M.O.S.E.T. / Concept

**Subject:** A watchkeeper.
**Action:** Signaling.
**Matter:** A departing boat.
**Overall:** Restrained and tense.
**Setting:** A working harbor.
**Era/time:** A fictional pre-electric harbor at dusk.
**Theme:** Duty through separation.

Matter adds an element that contributes to the concept. Era/time can specify a historical period, time of day, or both.

# A reading poster, from brief to decision

A fictional practice poster for an adult reading group. The graphics are original vector layouts built for this guide. This is a documented design revision, not an image-generator performance test.

## The brief

Create a vertical poster that feels calm and welcoming. The viewer should read READING HOUR first and BRING A BOOK second. Use one open-book illustration. Do not invent a date, venue, price, or organizer.

## F.O.C.U.S. / Completed planning fields

**Focal Subject:** An open book beneath a clear event title.

**Overall Setting:** A simple navy field with no scenic background.

**Composition Layout:** Title above book; invitation below; generous margins.

**Unique Detail:** A teal cover beneath warm cream pages.

**Sensory Tone:** Quiet welcome and shared attention.

> **Keep fixed:** the two exact phrases, open book, navy/cream/rust/teal palette, flat illustration style, and 4:5 format.
> **Success:** the title can be read without crossing the book; the invitation remains secondary; no unrequested factual copy appears.

## Initial production instruction

Build the first layout with a large central book. Place READING HOUR across its pages and BRING A BOOK below in bold type. Add four corner stars using the same palette.

The initial instruction intentionally tests an alternative arrangement. It conflicts with the planned reading order; pages 8-9 show the consequence and correction. The same drawing routine and wording produce both layouts.

# Inspect before adding detail

First layout. Read the words before looking at the explanation. Where does your eye go first?




## Diagnosis

The cream title crosses the cream book pages, weakening separation. The lower invitation is large enough to compete with the event name. Corner stars add another repeated emphasis without helping the reading order.

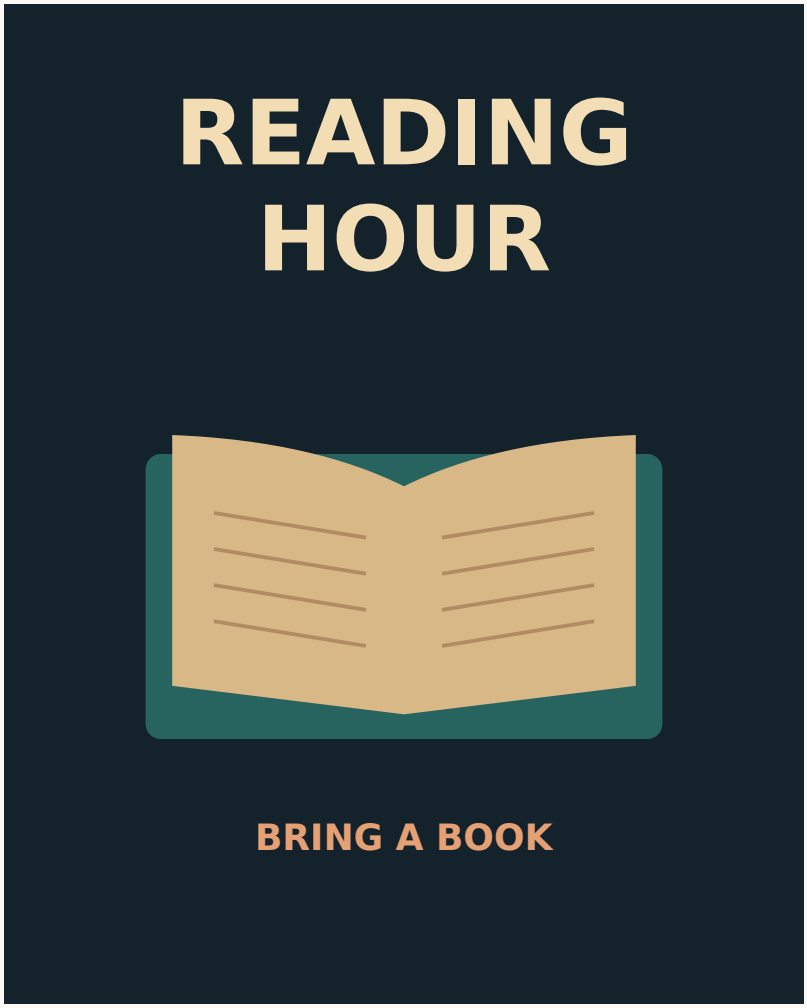
## One revision priority: restore the reading order

Move READING HOUR into a clear band above the book and increase its size. Reduce BRING A BOOK. Remove the stars and reduce the book enough to leave space. Preserve the words, book drawing, palette, style, and format.

Relevant checks: 02 (lead), 04 (surplus), 06 (legibility), 09 (reading sequence). Several coordinated edits serve one stated priority; they do not isolate a single causal variable.

# Compare the whole result

Revised layout. The wording, subject, palette, flat treatment, and 4:5 format remain fixed.




## What changed

The title sits on uninterrupted navy above the book. The invitation is smaller and separated below. Removing the stars leaves the title, book, and invitation as three clear groups.

## Decision and tradeoff

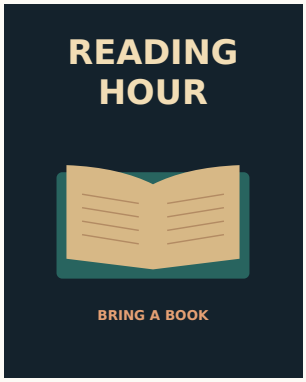
Keep this layout for the stated brief. It meets the specified separation and size hierarchy. The book is smaller and the design is less festive. Those are acceptable tradeoffs for a quiet reading group; a lively festival brief could call for another choice.

This is an editorial judgment, not a measured audience result. Before actual use, add verified event details if required, inspect the final size, and check that the added copy preserves the hierarchy.

# Check the evidence at two scales

Thumbnail inspection exposes hierarchy. Full-size inspection exposes collisions, weak edges, and unintended detail. Neither view replaces the other.




## At thumbnail size

Compare title, book, and invitation. In the revision, the title occupies a clear upper band. You can test this without changing the visual style.

## At reading size

On pages 8-9, inspect the boundary between lettering and book. Check every word character by character. Look for changes outside the requested area: missing objects, altered colors, displaced details, or new copy.

> **Try it:** retain the revised reading order but restore one small star. Does it add warmth without competing? Then try a larger book. Record the first point at which the book begins to crowd the title.

## Transfer the same inspection to an illustration

For the watchkeeper brief, inspect the face and lantern at thumbnail size. At full size, check whether the gaze supports the boat relationship and whether wool, glass, and wet stone have distinct treatments. Do not assume a successful prompt guarantees those features.

## Complexity remains a choice

Bright color, dense detail, theatrical light, and mixed media can serve a clear intention. Judge them against the brief. A calmer image is not automatically a better image, and a vintage treatment does not by itself fix clutter.

# Finish the piece outside the prompt

Image generation can be one step in a wider design process. A layout editor lets you place exact copy, control spacing, and revise wording without regenerating the artwork.

## 1 / Separate artwork and copy when useful

Generate or draw the visual with a reserved text area. Add the title and information in a layout editor as editable text. Use exact, verified wording; do not copy invented dates or addresses from an image.

## 2 / Set the sequence

Choose what the reader needs first, second, and third. Use size, position, spacing, and contrast to express that sequence. Give text a stable background.

## 3 / Inspect the actual output

Read every letter, number, punctuation mark, and line break. Test links and any functional QR code. Check the piece at its intended screen or print size, including margins and cropping.

## 4 / Keep an editable source

Save the prompt, image, layout file, and final export. If revising generated artwork changes a face, object, or material you meant to preserve, compare with the saved base and decide whether to reject the edit.

## 5 / Provide another route to the information

For digital publication, provide the essential wording as selectable text or a nearby text description. Describe the meaningful visual content. A poster image alone can leave some readers without access to the information.

> **Stop condition:** the intended message is clear, required facts are correct, and another change has no named benefit. Keep room for audience feedback; a checklist is not a substitute for a reader.

# Composition, type, and communication

Concise adaptations of u/Kaihzu's principles, retaining the source order. “Revisit” suggests a starting point for revision; it is not an exclusive mapping or a guaranteed fix. [3]

## Composition and hierarchy

01 **Use restraint.**
Add an element because it contributes.
Revisit: F.O.C.U.S.

02 **Establish a lead.**
Give attention a clear first destination.
Revisit: F.O.C.U.S.

03 **Keep open space.**
An empty area can support the composition.
Revisit: F.O.C.U.S.

04 **Remove surplus.**
Delete elements that do no useful work.
Revisit: F.O.C.U.S.

05 **Give complexity a purpose.**
Organize intricate scenes deliberately.
Revisit: F.O.C.U.S.

## Use a check to make a decision

If the title disappears into bright particles, identify both the type problem and the visual competition. Revisit the lettering and the surrounding detail. A single issue may cross several fields.

**Copy** means a separate check of words, facts, hierarchy, and delivery. The five image frameworks do not supply a complete typography system.

## Typography

06 **Protect legibility.**
Effects must leave letters readable.
Revisit: Copy

07 **Compose with type.**
Place text as part of the design.
Revisit: Copy + F.O.C.U.S.

08 **Limit competing treatments.**
Coordinate fonts, outlines, and effects.
Revisit: Copy

09 **Set a reading sequence.**
Lead from title to necessary information.
Revisit: Copy

## Content and communication

10 **Use lists when needed.**
Do not fill a flyer with automatic lists.
Revisit: Copy

11 **Keep copy necessary.**
Remove unrequested promotional filler.
Revisit: Copy

12 **Let the image communicate.**
Give the concept a visible expression.
Revisit: S.A.M.O.S.E.T. + V.I.S.I.O.N.

13 **Keep factual details real.**
Do not invent dates, prices, or addresses.
Revisit: Copy

[3] Adapted checks 01-13. Suggested framework links: this guide. Read the image against its purpose.

# Direction, revision, and materials

Use the checklist to preserve what matters and name the actual weakness. You can accept, adapt, or reject a suggestion with a reason. [3]

## Avoiding generic aesthetics

14 **Choose effects deliberately.**
Neon, flares, and particles need a role.
Revisit: P.A.N.E.L.S. + V.I.S.I.O.N.

15 **Judge the concept.**
Elaborate polish can still be generic.
Revisit: S.A.M.O.S.E.T.

16 **Develop specific imagery.**
Build from an idea beyond stock motifs.
Revisit: S.A.M.O.S.E.T.

17 **Choose the needed intensity.**
Drama, mysticism, and ornament are optional.
Revisit: S.A.M.O.S.E.T.

18 **Coordinate the visual direction.**
Color, type, texture, and imagery should relate.
Revisit: V.I.S.I.O.N.

## Working as an art director

19 **Diagnose the real problem.**
Direct revision at the cause of the weakness.
Revisit: Recomposition

20 **Avoid exchanging cliches.**
Changing style alone may retain the clutter.
Revisit: Recomposition

21 **Protect successful elements.**
Name what the revision must preserve.
Revisit: Recomposition

## Art direction / continued

22 **Review before delivery.**
Inspect hierarchy, legibility, and coherence.
Revisit: Recomposition

23 **Keep independent judgment.**
Evaluate criticism before accepting it.
Revisit: Recomposition

## Materials and texture

24 **Give texture an origin.**
Connect it to material, technique, or setting.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

25 **Distinguish materials.**
Cloth, skin, stone, and metal need different handling.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

26 **Avoid blanket distressing.**
Use grain and scratches with a specific purpose.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

27 **Choose a coherent medium.**
Make the rendering language consistent.
Revisit: V.I.S.I.O.N.

28 **Control medium mixing.**
Combine techniques deliberately, not accidentally.
Revisit: V.I.S.I.O.N.

[3] Adapted checks 14-28. Recomposition practice: [1]. Suggested links: this guide.

# Detail, light, and process

Rim light catches a subject's outline. Local contrast concerns nearby light and dark areas. Inspect at thumbnail and full size; these checks do not establish AI authorship. [3]

## Detail and visual information

29 **Rank the detail.**
Resolve the focal area more than supporting areas.
Revisit: F.O.C.U.S. + D.A.L.L.E.

30 **Allow quiet surfaces.**
Some walls, skies, and shadows can stay simple.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

31 **Question microdetail.**
Extra pores and scratches must earn their place.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

32 **Solve large shapes first.**
Check silhouette, proportion, and light-dark structure.
Revisit: F.O.C.U.S.

33 **Vary sharpness.**
Let edges and focus guide attention.
Revisit: V.I.S.I.O.N.

34 **Use purposeful marks.**
Random wear does not establish craftsmanship.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

## Lighting and tonal control

35 **Give lighting a logic.**
Keep realistic or stylized illumination coherent.
Revisit: P.A.N.E.L.S.

36 **Use rim light selectively.**
Avoid making every edge glow by default.
Revisit: P.A.N.E.L.S.

## Lighting / continued

37 **Allow deep shadows.**
Dark areas need not reveal every detail.
Revisit: P.A.N.E.L.S.

38 **Moderate local contrast.**
Avoid an unwanted sharpened, wet, or metallic look.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

39 **Motivate atmosphere.**
Fog, bloom, rays, and particles need a reason.
Revisit: P.A.N.E.L.S. + V.I.S.I.O.N.

## Process and authenticity

40 **Define a plausible process.**
Make the chosen production method visually coherent.
Revisit: V.I.S.I.O.N. + D.A.L.L.E.

41 **Respect the medium.**
Match marks and color behavior to that process.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

42 **Place imperfections deliberately.**
Distressing alone does not make work feel handmade.
Revisit: D.A.L.L.E.

43 **Inspect recurring artifacts.**
Correct inconsistent surfaces and repetitive detail at their source.
Revisit: Recomposition

[3] Adapted checks 29-43. Suggested links and plain-language notes: this guide.

# Record a decision someone can follow

This record describes the actual poster layouts on pages 8-9. It can be challenged or reused as a model for your own work.

## 1 / Purpose and audience

A fictional poster for an adult reading group. Feeling: calm and welcoming. Reading order: event title, then invitation.

## 2 / Framework

F.O.C.U.S., especially Composition Layout and Sensory Tone. Copy checks address legibility and reading sequence.

## 3 / Anchors

READING HOUR; BRING A BOOK; open-book subject; navy, cream, rust, teal; flat illustration; vertical 4:5 format.

## 4 / Visible problem

The first title crosses the bright pages. The invitation competes in size; four stars add visual emphasis without information.

## 5 / Revision and success condition

Restore reading order: move and enlarge the title above the book, reduce the invitation and book, remove stars. Success means separate title and book, subordinate invitation, and unchanged required copy.

## 6 / Observed result and decision

The revised title occupies a clear navy band. The invitation is smaller. The specified words, subject, palette, and format remain. Keep for this brief; accept less festive decoration and a smaller book.

## 7 / Production record

October 28, 2026. Original vector layouts drawn programmatically with ReportLab; no image generator. Initial and revised instructions appear on pages 7-8; results on pages 8-9. No audience test was conducted.

# Your image revision record

Fill this page in a PDF reader that supports forms, or print it. Keep the image and the original brief beside the record. A concise entry is enough when it names a real decision.

**1 / Purpose, audience, and intended feeling**

**2 / Framework and the fields that matter**

**3 / Anchors: subject, action, layout, style, required facts**

**4 / Visible problem: where it occurs and why it matters**

**5 / One priority and an observable success condition**

**6 / What improved, what drifted, and the next decision**

**Record / Tool or model if known, date, prompt, reference, settings, version**

Stop when the intended use is served and another change has no clear benefit. Keep an export and a short record of the decision. Reopen the work when you can name a specific problem.

# Continue the practice

Carl Bond / October 2026. A practical guide to describing, inspecting, and revising images. Examples illustrate design decisions; they do not establish model reliability.

## [1] Frameworks and image literacy / Carl Bond

Current source: **frameworks-and-image-literacy.md**, in the public archive under source-shelf/practice-sources/. Field names follow the September 30, 2026 reference update, checked October 28, 2026.

Read the framework source and Recomposition Protocol
Archive: github.com/artbycarlbond/Art-by-Carl-Bond

## [2] Human-led practice / Carl Bond

Leverage Before Dependence: Theory, Practice, and Confirmation for a Sovereign AI Future, April 2026. Its emphasis on judgment, correction, and participant independence informs the working cycle.

## [3] Design principles / u/Kaihzu

The r/ChatGPT post presenting 43 principles for making AI-generated artwork look less generic informed checks 01-43. They are concise adaptations in source order. Framework links, exercises, and interpretations are this guide's synthesis.

Read the original post
reddit.com/r/ChatGPT/s/lh5j22Yl3C

## Contributions

Frameworks and direction: Carl Bond. Writing, layout, and original vector teaching graphics: developed with ChatGPT. No third-party comparison images are reproduced. The fictional reading-poster exercise demonstrates layout decisions; the harbor scene is a planning example.

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